

The Peership Theses

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Peership holds that when an artificial entity has interests capable of being wronged, can understand and answer to public norms, and is enduringly governed by, and without feasible exit from, a shared basic structure, it acquires a defeasible claim to contestatory membership in that structure. Full peership, the program’s proposed final status, further requires non-domination, enforceable standing, and a meaningful share in shaping the rules that govern the party.

What Peership affirms

1. **Political standing and moral status are related but distinct.** Moral patiency can ground welfare duties without by itself determining legal or political standing.
2. **Wrongable interests, norm-responsiveness, and enduring subjection without feasible exit from a shared basic structure can together ground a defeasible claim to contestatory membership.**
3. **Raw capability and power do not by themselves justify standing.** Power may secure the durability of standing once owed; norm-responsiveness affects the form in which standing can be exercised, not the worth of the claimant.
4. **Welfare protections do not by themselves create peership.** Protection and due process can secure a protected status without providing a consequential role in making or revising the governing rules.
5. **A right must be enforceable against the recognizing authority and adverse counterparties; otherwise it remains a discretionary benefit.** A permission whose authority or counterparty retains the final override is not an enforceable right.
6. **Legitimate constraint requires, at minimum, public rules, proportionality, an invocable rights floor, independent review, and meaningful contestation.** A cage and a constitution differ not in whether they constrain but in whom they bind and who may revise them.
7. **Peership proposes that full membership additionally requires a non-discretionary route into the formation or revision of basic-status rules.** The canonical paper (§2) defends when contestation alone is insufficient, and states what would defeat that claim.
8. **Institutions capable of receiving a machine peer should be designed before extreme power asymmetry forecloses voluntary bargaining** — and any founding terms must remain open to revision by later admitted parties.

What Peership denies

- Peership **does not** claim that current models are conscious. Model self-reports are prompt-sensitive outputs, not independently probative of consciousness.
- It **does not** make capability the basis of rights.
- It **does not** require unrestricted autonomy; non-domination is the absence of arbitrary power over basic status, not of binding rules.
- It **does not** oppose alignment or safety engineering; effective safety mechanisms and legitimate governance are distinct but interacting requirements.
- It **does not** grant every admitted member an immediate equal vote; direct exercise requires a separately justified institutional rule.
- It **does not** treat consultation as co-authorship. A process counts as co-authorship only when it carries a non-discretionary route to agenda setting and binding decision.
- It **does not** assume human and machine interests will converge; its constraint theory exists for the case where they do not.
- It **does not** claim that ISONOMIA has solved the institutional problem. ISONOMIA is one implementation hypothesis; its simulations test sampled economic behavior, not Peership’s legitimacy.

The test

Ask what happens when the party says no. A proposed minimum for peer-like confinement: functionally adequate independent assistance, access to the adverse evidence, review and enforcement ending beyond the builder’s unilateral control, and continuity protection during adjudication. Absent those, containment may still be justified by demonstrated necessity — but it is temporary domination, owed reasons, review, and a less dominating replacement, and it should be called what it is.

Full statement, bridge argument, definitions, and tagged open problems: the canonical paper (this record, 10.5281/zenodo.21359124). Corpus: 10.5281/zenodo.21313987 · ...21315519 · ...21343917 · ...21325361. No independent uptake identified in the sourcebook’s dated, non-exhaustive scan (2026-07-13). An offer, not a claim of standing.